

Phizura: On-the-Fly Music Recording with Method Proxies

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Abstract

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Keywords

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1. Abstract

Live coding is a performance practice in which artists write and modify code in real time to generate music. A key challenge is capturing a performance for later replay, sharing, or analysis without resorting to audio recording. This paper presents Phizura, a recording tool for on-the-fly music performances conducted with Coypu, a Pharo-based library and dialect for live music programming. Phizura leverages Method Proxies, a safe and fast message-passing control library, to non-intrusively intercept Playground evaluations and keystrokes during a performance. The recorded data, timestamped expressions and input events, can later be emitted as executable Pharo code that faithfully replays the performance with the original timing. We describe the architecture of Phizura, detail how Method Proxies enable a clean separation between recording logic and the Coypu codebase, and compare the approach to a previous Announcer-based implementation.

2. Introduction

Live coding is an increasingly popular creative practice in which performers write and modify source code in real time to produce music, visuals, or other time-based media¹. The field has developed a substantial academic presence: the International Conference on Live Coding (ICLC), now in its tenth year, has served as the primary venue for peer-reviewed research on the practice, attracting contributions from computer science, music, and the performing arts. Programming languages such as Tidal Cycles[?], Sonic Pi[?], and Orca[?] have popularized the practice, each offering alternative syntaxes and notations for expressing musical patterns. Within the Pharo ecosystem, Coypu[?] provides a library and a DSL for on-the-fly music programming, enabling performers to construct rhythmic sequences, melodic patterns, and to modify them interactively in a Playground.

To date, relatively little scholarly attention has been devoted to capturing and preserving live coding performances, particularly the generative process itself. Audio recording captures the sonic result but discards the compositional process: the sequence of code edits, evaluations, and their precise timing. Audio files are also large, difficult to share, and impossible to re-execute under a different setup. Compositional data, by contrast, enables exact replay of a performance with alternative sound synthesis, facilitates sharing between musicians as lightweight text files, supports analysis of live coding practice, and opens the door to automated post-processing of performances. This concern has been

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¹TOPLAP Manifesto

raised explicitly in the Tidal Cycles community², where users have discussed the need for tools that store every evaluation with its timestamp and allow session-based replay. However, no integrated solution has emerged so far.

This paper presents the design and implementation of Phizura, shows how Method Proxies[?] can be applied beyond profiling and debugging to support creative coding workflows, and compares the current approach to the previous Announcer-based implementation. The paper begins with background on Coypu and Method Proxies, then discusses the limitations of the earlier Announcer-based approach that motivated the redesign. It continues with the architecture and implementation of Phizura, the code emission and replay mechanism, and a discussion of related work. It closes with a reflection on generality, limitations, and future directions.

3. Background

3.1. Coypu: programming music on-the-fly with Pharo

Coypu[?] is a library and domain-specific dialect for live music programming within the Pharo environment. It acts as a client for an audio server, which can be either internal (a Phausto[?] DSP running within Pharo) or an external OSC-capable application, typically SuperCollider via the SuperDirt engine, or a MIDI device. A performer works in a Pharo Playground, writing expressions that define rhythmic and melodic patterns and assign them to named instruments. Once evaluated, these patterns begin playing immediately. From that point on, the performer reshapes the music in real time: modifying patterns, muting or soloing individual voices, swapping instruments, and layering new material over what is already running. Every evaluation hits the running output immediately. The performance is shaped by what gets evaluated, when, and in what order and that is exactly what Phizura records.

3.2. Method Proxies: dynamic method interception in Pharo

Method Proxies[?] is a message-passing control library for Pharo that lets you dynamically instrument any method to run user-defined actions before and after its execution. The idea is simple: you tell the framework which method you want to intercept, and you hand it a handler that says what to do around it.

A handler is an instance of a subclass of `MpHandler`. It defines two hooks: `beforeExecutionWithReceiver:arguments:`, which fires right before the original method runs, and `afterExecutionWithReceiver:arguments:returnValue:`, which fires after it returns. That is all the user needs to care about — everything else is managed under the hood. Internally, when a method is instrumented, the framework replaces the original compiled method in the method dictionary with a copy of a pre-compiled trap method template. Through literal patching, this trap wires in references to the actual handler and to the original method, which is preserved under a mangled selector. The trap leverages Pharo's stack unwinding mechanism via a marker primitive to guarantee execution of the after-hook without allocating block closures, making it significantly faster than `ensure:-`-based approaches. Method Proxies also takes care of the tricky parts. A per-thread meta-level detection mechanism prevents infinite recursion when the instrumentation code itself triggers instrumented methods. Thread safety, non-local returns, exceptions, and clean uninstrumentation are all handled by the framework. The entry point is `MpMethodProxy`, which manages installing and removing the instrumentation. The users just define what happens before and after, and the result is code that is easier to maintain and extend.

²Tidal Club Forum, How to replay a live coding session, link, 2020.

4. Previous Approach: Announcers and Announcements

The first recording mechanism for Coypu was implemented by Redwane Engels during an internship and demonstrated at ESUG 2024 in Lille. It relied on Pharo's `Announcer` and `Announcement` classes, which implement the observer design pattern.

The approach was straightforward: the Coypu codebase itself was modified so that at each point where an evaluation could produce a musical effect, an announcement was explicitly fired. A subscriber object, the recorder, registered interest in these announcements and logged each one with a timestamp.

It functioned as intended, but introduced significant trade-offs. Recording logic was distributed throughout the codebase, and supporting each new recordable event required direct modifications to the source code. The recorder depended on specific announcement classes defined within the library, making the two systems difficult to evolve independently. Extending it to capture additional events, such as keystrokes, cursor positions, or events from other tools, required yet more invasive changes. And every modification to the evaluation pipeline risked breaking or silently bypassing the recording hooks. These limitations motivated the redesign using Method Proxies, which externalizes the instrumentation entirely.

5. Design and Implementation

Phizura is organized in three packages: `Phizura` (core recording and emission logic), `Phizura-Playground` (UI integration), and `Phizura-Tests` (test suite). The architecture addresses four concerns: instrumentation, recording, code emission, and UI integration.

5.1. Instrumentation

At the core of Phizura's design is a small class hierarchy for instrumentation. `PhizuraInstrumentor` is an abstract class that manages a collection of `MpMethodProxy` instances and a shared `PhizuraHandler`. Subclasses define which methods to instrument by implementing `initializeMethodProxies`.

```
PhizuraInstrumentor >> initialize
  super initialize.
  instrumentationHandler := PhizuraHandler
    onRecorder: recorder.
  self initializeProxyVariables.
  self initializeMethodProxies
```

Listing 1: Initialization of `PhizuraInstrumentor`

The concrete subclass `PhizuraEvaluationInstrumentor` instruments two methods: `SpCodeSelectionCommand>>#evaluate:andDo:`, the standard Pharo Playground evaluation command, and `PhizuraPlaygroundPagePresenter>>#doEvaluateAndGoFor:`, the Phizura Playground's own evaluation path. Both share the same handler instance, so all evaluations are recorded uniformly regardless of which path triggers them.

The handler itself, `PhizuraHandler`, is a subclass of `MpHandler` and constitutes the only user-defined hook in the entire system. It implements a single method:

```
PhizuraHandler >> beforeExecutionWithReceiver:
  anObject arguments: anArrayOfArguments
  | argument |
  argument := anArrayOfArguments first.
  recorder addRecord:
    (PhizuraEvaluationRecordEntry new
      time: DateAndTime now;
      expression: argument;
```

```

cursorPosition:
    playgroundPage text cursorPosition;
yourself)

```

Listing 2: PhizuraHandler before-execution hook

The handler extracts the first argument of the intercepted method, which is the expression string being evaluated, and creates a record entry with three pieces of information: the current timestamp, the expression text, and the cursor position in the editor. No Coypu method is modified, subclassed, or even referenced. The instrumentation is purely additive.

5.2. Recording

Phizura captures two kinds of events, modeled by a small class hierarchy rooted at `PhizuraBasicRecordEntry`. `PhizuraEvaluationRecordEntry` stores a code expression, a timestamp, and the cursor position, corresponding to Playground evaluations. `PhizuraKeyEventRecordEntry` stores a keyboard key, a timestamp, and the cursor position, captured via a `whenKeyUpDo:` event handler on the Playground's text presenter, independently of Method Proxies. Both entry types participate in double dispatch for code emission (see Section 5).

`PhizuraRecorder` ties the system together. It holds a collection of record entries, a reference to the instrumentor, and a boolean recording flag. When `record` is called, it creates a `PhizuraEvaluationInstrumentor`, installs the proxies, and sets the flag. When `stopRecording` is called, it uninstalls all proxies. A guard `isRecording ifTrue:` ensures that evaluations outside a recording session are not captured. For emergency recovery, a class-side `forceUnrecord` method uninstalls all proxies in the image.

5.3. The Phizura Playground

Phizura requires a custom Playground to intercept the text that is evaluated when the user presses Cmd+D (Do it). The standard Pharo Playground does not expose the evaluated expression in a way that can be captured externally. The expression text flows through internal methods that are not designed for observation. To solve this, Phizura provides its own Playground, built by subclassing the standard Pharo Playground classes at four points.

`PhizuraPlaygroundPresenter`, a subclass of `StPlaygroundPresenter`, manages the window lifecycle. It ensures that recording stops when the window is closed and creates instances of `PhizuraPlaygroundPage` instead of the default page.

`PhizuraPlaygroundPagePresenter`, a subclass of `StPlaygroundPagePresenter`, is the central customization point. It defines the method `doEvaluateAndGoFor:`, which receives the selected text as its argument and evaluates it. This method is one of the two targets instrumented by Method Proxies, and it is where the handler intercepts the expression being evaluated. In addition, this presenter initializes the recorder, registers a `whenKeyUpDo:` event handler to capture keystrokes, sets up a custom interaction model via `PhizuraPlaygroundInteractionModel`, and extends the toolbar with five commands: `Phizurear` (toggle recording), `Clean Phizura` (reset the recorder), `Inspect Phizura` (open an inspector on the recorder), `Open MoofLOD` (emit code with OSC messages), and `Open Records` (emit clean performance code).

`PhizuraPlaygroundPage`, a subclass of `StPlaygroundPage`, overrides `defaultObjectInspectorClass` to return `PhizuraPlaygroundPagePresenter`, ensuring the custom presenter is used. `PhizuraPlaygroundInteractionModel`, a subclass of `StPlaygroundInteractionModel`, allows binding a custom `doItReceiver`, giving the Playground page presenter access to itself as the evaluation context.

A global variable `PhiRecorderInstance` holds the active recorder, initialized when the Phizura Playground opens. The Phizura Playground is accessible from the Pharo world menu and can be opened programmatically via `PhizuraPlayground open`.

6. Code Emission and Replay

A key feature of Phizura is its ability to emit executable code from recorded data. The `PhizuraCodeEmitter` class iterates over the record entries and produces Pharo source code that, when evaluated inside a forked block, replays the performance with the original timing.

6.1. Timing Reconstruction

The emitter computes the delay between consecutive entries by subtracting their timestamps. Each delay is then expressed as a wait statement in the generated code, so that when the emitted script runs in a forked process, the original temporal structure of the performance is faithfully reconstructed.

6.2. Emission Modes

Phizura supports two code emission modes, implemented via double dispatch between the emitter and the record entries.

The first mode, accessed through `emitPerformanceCode`, produces clean, executable Coypu code. Keystroke events are filtered out and only evaluation records are emitted, separated by the appropriate delays. The resulting script is self-contained: anyone with the same Coypu setup and sound definitions can evaluate it to hear the exact performance.

```
[
ep := EcoPhausto new.
1.0 seconds wait.
ep playFor: 512 bars.
1.5 seconds wait.
#(1 0 0 1 0 0 0 0) asSeq to: #kick.
1.8 seconds wait.
#rumba asRhythm to: #conga.
] fork.
```

Listing 3: Example of emitted performance code

The second mode, accessed through `emitMoofLODCode`, extends the performance code with OSC-compatible messages. After each expression, a string representation is sent via `toLocal: 'evaluatedCommand'`. Keystroke events emit the key value and cursor coordinates. This mode enables external visualization tools or network-based synchronization during replay.

Both modes rely on double dispatch on the record entry side, through the methods `emitPerformanceCodeOnEmitter:onStream:` and `emitMoofLODCodeOnEmitter:onStream:`. This makes it straightforward to add new emission formats without modifying the record entry classes or the emitter's core iteration logic.

7. Related Work

The challenge of recording and replaying live coding sessions has received relatively little attention in the literature. In the Tidal Cycles community, a forum discussion³ explicitly outlines requirements that Phizura addresses: storing every evaluation with its timestamp, handling sessions with start and stop, and enabling replay. The thread concludes without a solution, noting the absence of such a tool across live coding environments.

The most directly comparable work is Live Writing by Lee and Essl[?], presented at ICLC 2015. During a Gibber live coding session in the browser, Live Writing records keystroke-level data: every character typed, cursor position, and timestamp. The system captures the typing performance, that is, how the code was physically entered. Live Writing is implemented via CodeMirror editor hooks in

³Tidal Club Forum, How to replay a live coding session, link, 2020.

the browser, whereas Phizura uses reflective instrumentation through Method Proxies, requiring no modification to the editor or the live coding library.

Another related effort is SHARP[?], a Pulsar⁴ extension that visualizes the history of each instrument a live coder creates, providing an interactive tree-like structure to track how blocks of code evolve over time and to revisit previous states. It addresses the versioning aspect of the creative process. SHARP manages the evaluated expressions but does not capture timing or produce replayable scripts. Phizura and SHARP are complementary: SHARP preserves the structural history of code, while Phizura preserves the temporal performance.

⁴Pulsar (<https://pulsar-edit.dev>) is a community-maintained, open-source text editor built on Electron, forked from GitHub's Atom after its discontinuation.